than 6 per cent of the vote; the party now claims that "over 30 AAP MLAs" are in touch with them in Punjab. "The Congress has been saying this for the past three years," Mann told the waiting media in dismissive tones after the meeting with Kejriwal. "We have built this party with our blood and sweat—leaving is out of the question."

The body language of his legislators, though, couldn't exactly be described as upbeat. It was, after all, the spectacular rise of AAP in Delhi circa 2013 that had sowed its seeds in Punjab: in the 2014 Lok Sabha polls, AAP candidates took four out of the state's 13 seats. That groundswell came to full fruition by the 2022 assembly election, where AAP shocked everyone by storming to power with 92 seats in the 117-member assembly. In the past three years, these numbers have risen to 95. Last year saw a reality check, though, with AAP managing just three seats in the Lok Sabha election. It was put down to Mann's leadership fumbles and Kejriwal's arrest in the liquor scam case. But local morale was still intact. That gets submitted to a stern test now.

Meanwhile, in Delhi, AAP's 22 MLAs, led by seniors like Atishi and Gopal Rai, will keep up the pressure on the BJP government. The immediate priority will be ensuring AAP gets control of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), the main hub of financial and administrative power. Tactically and materially, AAP had lost turf while being locked in a bruising war of control over administrative space with the lieutenant governor's office. It will not want to cede more ground with the MCD. Party insiders say Kejriwal and his close aides are overseeing this priority project.

But then, the BJP also has its eyes on the MCD, and now claims to have the numbers to claim majority. The party has 120 councillors while AAP numbers are down to 122. MCD also has 14 MLA votes (proportional representation) along with seven Lok Sabha and three Rajya Sabha ones. With its present strength in the assembly and LS in Delhi, the BJP will feel confident. Sources say a no-confidence motion against Delhi's AAP mayor Mahesh Khichi is also in the works. The idea, of course, is to further demoralise AAP's mid-tier leadership.

Further complicating the situation for Kejriwal, the Amit Shah-led home ministry has given sanction to the Enforcement Directorate to prosecute him in the excise policy-linked money laundering case. BJP insiders believe there is a strong possibility that he may have to face arrest again in the case.

Mann's regime in Punjab also seems to have slid on the popularity scales. The show of solidarity in Delhi aside, sources say there is resentment among his own partymen. In October, Kejriwal, after he came out on bail, had pushed changes in the state, which included a cabinet rejig. At least four of Mann's associates were dropped. The CM also lost the post of state unit chief to minister Aman Arora, Kejriwal's pick. All these were seen as steps to shift the power centre from Chandigarh to Delhi. There was much buzz then that a section of AAP legislators in Punjab were building pressure on Kejriwal to replace Mann.

And that base is another source of worry. Among AAP's 95 legislators in Punjab now, at least 40 are turncoats from various parties, chiefly the Congress. Leader of the Opposition and Congress leader Partap Singh Bajwa has now stirred the pot, claiming over 30 AAP MLAs are in touch with him. He also speculated that Mann may himself break the party to join hands with the BJP. Mind games for sure: the state BJP's own house is not quite in order, so it may not look particularly fetching as a potential habitat to a top-level émigré.

That said, AAP's Delhi defeat could be just the right trigger for a spot of intensified factionalism in the Punjab unit, with both the Delhi players and the Mann camp jostling for control. This may create new openings for both the state BJP and Congress.

As for Kejriwal, things may not look so good right now but, as the original weathervane of Indian politics Ram Vilas Paswan used to say, no one is ever truly finished politically unless he sits at home and sulks after a defeat. Kejriwal has no such plans. He will stay in motion, in sight: visibility has been the rocket fuel of his politics. Then there are those cases. He'll certainly have no time to sulk. ■

## WHAT NEXT FOR KEJRI AND AAP

- **Rebuild party image:** Take the corruption allegations head on, fulfil unmet promises in Punjab and MCD in Delhi to regain public trust
- **Spruce up governance:** In Punjab, it'll have to double down on the welfarism pitch, showcase the party's governance model
- **Legal challenges:** Work closely to stay ahead in the legal cat-and-mouse game over the excise policy case a.k.a. the liquor scam
- **Political alliances:** Assess AAP's ties within the Opposition bloc and re-engage for the long game against the BJP
- **Back to the grassroots:** AAP has to keep grassroots supporters–its core voter base in slums and unauthorised colonies–galvanised in Delhi

**STABILITY IN PUNJAB IS TOP PRIORITY NOW, EVEN IF MANN DISPELS BAZAAR TALK OF A CAVE-IN. EXPECT TO SEE MORE OF KEJRIWAL THERE, MAYBE EVEN AS A RAJYA SABHA MP**